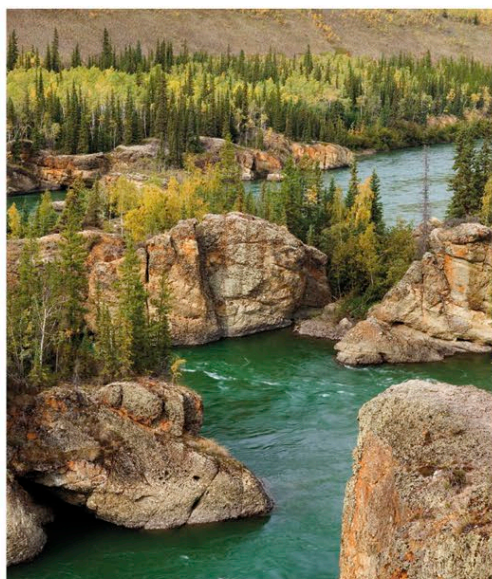




△ HAZARDOUS PASSAGE

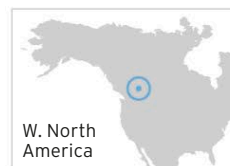
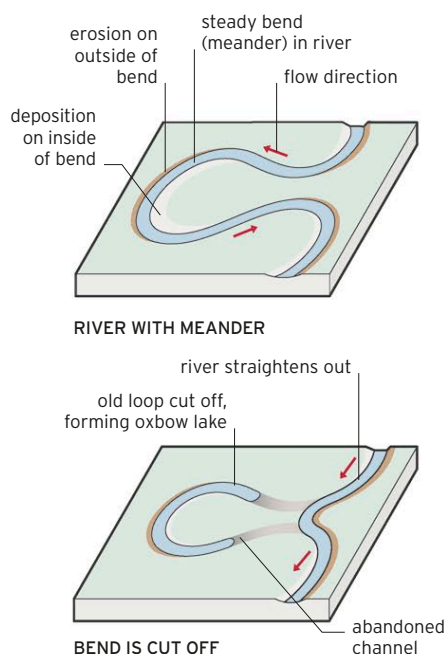
One of the best-known landmarks on the Yukon River, the Five Finger Rapids is a point at which the river splits into channels around four large rock towers. It presented a hazardous obstacle to early gold prospectors.

◁ WINDING COURSE

For much of its lower course, the Yukon is a slow, winding river with many large meanders and oxbow lakes scattered throughout its floodplain.

HOW AN OXBOW LAKE FORMS

Erosion and deposition make the shape of a river meander more and more accentuated over time. Eventually, the river cuts its course across the neck of the loop and follows a more direct route. The abandoned section forms a distinctive U-shaped oxbow lake.



Lake Abraham

A glacial lake with unusual natural sculptures captured within its frozen surface during winter

Lake Abraham is an artificial lake created by the damming of the North Saskatchewan River in northern Alberta, Canada, in 1972. It stretches 20 miles (32 km), oriented north to south along the river valley, and is 2 miles (3.3 km) across at its widest.

What lies beneath

For much of the year, Lake Abraham displays the turquoise waters seen in most glacial lakes of the Canadian Rockies. However, during winter, beneath its clear, icy surface, bizarre frozen stacks of cotton-wool-like bubbles appear. These amazing formations actually contain highly flammable methane gas produced as bacteria at the bottom of the lake decompose dead organic material. In summer, the methane simply rises to the surface and escapes, but in winter the gas is trapped—and held on dazzling display—until the spring thaw.



△ BUBBLE STACKS

Bubbles of methane gas rising from the bottom of the lake are trapped in ice as they reach the colder surface, with successive bubbles freezing in stacks.